

SYNTHETIC — illustrative, not from any real company. Written for a portfolio RAG project; does not describe any real internal procedure.

Chargeback Handling Runbook

Runbook ID: RUN-CHG-003 | Effective: April 15, 2026

Use this runbook when a card issuer notifies the store of a customer- initiated chargeback — distinct from a refund request made directly to the store; a chargeback is initiated with the customer's bank, bypassing the store entirely, and requires a formal response within the issuer's deadline (typically 10–14 business days) or the chargeback is automatically decided in the customer's favor.

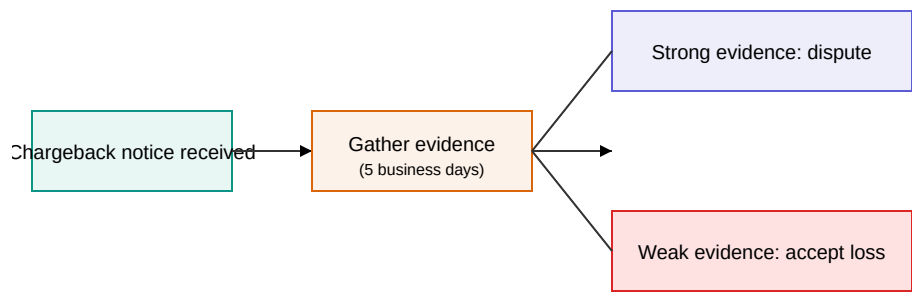


Figure 1: Chargeback response decision flow. "Accept loss" does not require store-manager approval below \$200; disputing always does, regardless of amount.

Gathering Evidence

Within 5 business days of the chargeback notice, gather: the original receipt/order confirmation, delivery confirmation if shipped, any signed delivery acknowledgment, the customer's return/refund history for context, and — critically — confirmation of whether a refund was already issued through normal channels before the chargeback was filed. A chargeback filed after a refund was already processed through RET-POL-001 or the Failed Refund Runbook (RUN-REF-001) is a strong case for dispute, since the customer has effectively attempted to be refunded twice.

Deciding Whether to Dispute

Evidence	Recommendation
Delivery confirmed, no refund already issued, no return record	Dispute — strong case
Refund already issued via RET-POL-001 before chargeback filed	Dispute — strong case
Delivery unconfirmed or address mismatch	Accept loss — weak case
Chargeback reason is "product not as described"	Accept loss unless photos/inspection notes exist — weak case by default

Filing the Dispute

Disputes are filed through the payment processor's merchant portal, not directly with the card issuer. Include all evidence gathered above as a single combined document, not separate attachments — processors have historically deprioritized multi-attachment submissions in queue, per processor guidance shared with the finance team in 2025.

Interaction with Payment Gateway Incidents

If the original transaction date falls within a known payment gateway incident window (see the Payment Gateway Failure Postmortem, error code POS-ERR-3045), note this explicitly in the dispute evidence — issuers generally rule in the merchant's favor when a documented service incident explains an otherwise-ambiguous transaction pattern the customer might otherwise successfully dispute.

Outcome Tracking

Log every chargeback outcome (won, lost, or withdrawn by the customer) against the runbook's own tracking sheet, separate from the general refund tracking used for RUN-REF-001. Chargeback loss rate is reviewed monthly; a rate trending upward for a specific reason code is escalated to the finance team as a potential process gap, not treated as isolated incidents.

Related Documents

RET-POL-001 — Returns Policy · RUN-REF-001 — Failed Refund Runbook · POS-ERR-3045 — Payment Gateway Failure Postmortem